

COMMENTARY: Latah County Library District goes the distance to reach residents

George Williams 

George Williams, Latah County Library District

There's a quote from "The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy" that I've always remembered - "Space ... is big. Really big. You just won't believe how vastly hugely mind-bogglingly big it is. I mean, you may think it's a long way down the road to the chemist, but that's just peanuts to space."

I was thinking of this quote last Thursday when I filled in for our regular library courier, who was sick. In one short day, I got to visit most of the libraries in the Latah County Library District - and it's big. Really big. Well, not as big as space, but I think you get the idea. Latah County is 1,077 square-miles, only about 140 square-miles smaller than the state of Rhode Island. We're incredibly lucky that the whole county is one single library district. My wife used to teach in Canyon County, where many residents who live outside of Nampa or Caldwell cannot get free library cards because they are not within any library district. We're fortunate that we have a library system that covers all county residents.

But while Latah County is big, (really big) we're also lucky that we're part of an even bigger library system, VALNet. It's been almost two years since we joined VALNet and began sharing materials with the nearly 60 libraries who are members. And while we have our own courier system that covers the library district twice per week, VALNet has a courier system in place that covers most of its system - from Elk City, Grangeville, and Kooskia in the southeast, to Clarkston

and Moscow in the west and north - five times per week.

I kept all of this in my mind as I went to our Latah County libraries last week and I took many photos for the library's Flickr account (www.flickr.com/latahlibrary). I took photos of the majestic view at the Juliaetta Library, some great shots of the Christmas decorations you can see at the libraries in Deary and Genesee and almost 20 photos of the historic library building in Bovill. Of course, all of this fun did come to an end when I stopped on a side road about half way between Genesee and Moscow to take a picture of the nice view of Moscow and I ended up falling in a hole.

So, as I'm writing this now, I'd just like to take the opportunity to tell everyone in the area that you should go out there and experience our large and diverse library district. If you live in Moscow, you should consider remaking the infamous "Bovill Run" but instead of visiting the bars, you should visit the local libraries. With a little creative driving you might even be able to fit Genesee, Juliaetta, and Potlatch into your route as our courier does twice a week. But be careful if you stop by the side of the road to take any photos because we are in Idaho and there are lots of holes and ditches to fall into. Fortunately for me, the hole I fell into was small. Fairly small.

George Williams is access services manager for the Latah County Library District.

